

conversations were designed to answer this leap-of-faith question: do people find it frustrating to pay bills by hand? It turned out that they did, and this early validation gave Cook the confirmation he needed to get started on a solution.⁹

Those early conversations did not delve into the product features of a proposed solution; that attempt would have been foolish. The average consumers at that time were not conversant enough with personal computers to have an opinion about whether they'd want to use them in a new way. Those early conversations were with mainstream customers, not early adopters. Still, the conversations yielded a fundamental insight: if Intuit could find a way to solve this problem, there could be a large mainstream audience on which it could build a significant business.

Design and the Customer Archetype

The goal of such early contact with customers is not to gain definitive answers. Instead, it is to clarify at a basic, coarse level that we understand our potential customer and what problems they have. With that understanding, we can craft a customer archetype, a brief document that seeks to humanize the proposed target customer. This archetype is an essential guide for product development and ensures that the daily prioritization decisions that every product team must make are aligned with the customer to whom the company aims to appeal.

There are many techniques for building an accurate customer archetype that have been developed over long years of practice in the design community. Traditional approaches such as interaction design or design thinking are enormously helpful. To me, it has always seemed ironic that many of these approaches are highly experimental and iterative, using techniques such as rapid prototyping and in-person customer observations to guide designers' work. Yet because of the way design agencies traditionally have been compensated, all this work culminates in a monolithic deliverable to the client. All of a sudden, the rapid